

Emacs support for M4 preprocessor

Description	Keystroke	Function	Note
The M4 preprocessor	Emacs has built-in support for the m4 preprocessor files: the m4-mode . PEL provides extra support once the  pel-use-m4 user-option is turned on (set to t): - The following extra customization user-options to control M4 editing accessible via the <f11> SPC 4 <f2> key sequence or <f12> <f2> from within a M4 buffer once PEL support was activated: pel-use-m4 : activates PEL extra M4 support. pel-m4-activates-minor-modes : Specify extra minor modes automatically activated in M4 buffer. Defaults to none. pel-m4-tab-width : Specify the value stored in the 'tab-width' user-option in M4 buffer. Used to control the display rendering of hard tabs. Defaults to 4. For M4 that also corresponds to the indentation width when hard tabs are not used. pel-use-tabs : Specify whether hard tabs are inserted in M4 source code files. Off by defaults; inserting spaces instead of hard tabs.		
	Last updated on: 2026-09-19		
Open this PDF file. See also: ⓘ Help/Info	<f11> SPC 4 <f1>	(pel-help-pdf & optional OPEN-WEB-PAGE)	Open the ⓘ - m4 local PDF. With C-u , M-- , M- -1 or C- -1 prefix: open the remote GitHub hosted PDF instead. If the pel-flip-help-pdf-arg user-option is set it's the other way around.
	<f12> <f1>		
 ⓘ Customize PEL m4 support	<f11> SPC 4 <f2>	(pel-customize-pel & optional OTHER-WINDOW)	Customize PEL m4 support If OTHER-WINDOW is non-nil (use C-u), display in another window.
	<f12> <f2>		
 ⓘ Customize Emacs m4 support	<f11> SPC 4 <f3>	(pel-customize-library & optional OTHER-WINDOW)	Customize Emacs m4 support If OTHER-WINDOW is non-nil (use C-u), display in another window.
	<f12> <f3>		

m4— References

Document	Notes
m4 preprocessor	
m4 computer language @ Wikipedia	Overview, history, features and implementations of m4.
GNU M4 home page	Provides links to: GNU m4 project page on savannah GNU m4 download page m4 Git depot tree
GNU m4 manual	Manual of m4 version 1.4.19
Introductory material	The following document provide a good introduction to m4. Reading those before reading the manual helps. Notes on the M4 Macro Language - Michael Breen © 2008 — Very well written.
Comments in m4 inputs	- Comments start with # - Comments are not discarded by m4 and show in m4 standard output - Comments delimited can be changed at any time with the changecom macro
Emacs Support for m4	m4-mode .